

JAPAN TRAVEL GUIDE & ITINERARY

A 14-Day Relaxed Journey: Pop Culture, Sacred Temples & 100% Gluten-Free Vegan Dining

Trip Overview

Duration: 14 Days (Mid-to-Late May)
Destinations: Tokyo (7 Days) & Kyoto (7 Days)
Pacing: Relaxed, low-stress, zero-rush itinerary.
Focus: Anime/Pop Culture, Historic Shrines, GF Vegan Eats.

May Weather & Travel Conditions

Temperature: 18°C – 24°C (64°F – 75°F) - Ideal warmth.
Golden Week Warning: Ends early May. Traveling mid-to-late May guarantees post-holiday calm and low crowds.
Packing: Comfortable walking shoes, light layers.

Relaxed & Stress-Free Travel: Flight & Delay-Mitigation Strategy

To eliminate flight delays, cancellations, and transit anxiety, follow these strategic guidelines:

- **Non-Stop Direct Flights:** Book non-stop direct routes to Tokyo Haneda (HND) or Narita (NRT). Haneda is preferred as it is only 30 minutes from central Tokyo via the Tokyo Monorail or Keikyu Line.
- **Morning Departures:** Early morning flights have a 85%+ higher on-time performance rate than evening departures.
- **Shinkansen (Bullet Train) Smart Booking:** Use the official *SmartEX App* to pre-book reserved seats on the Shinkansen between Tokyo and Kyoto. Book seats in Row 1-5 for extra legroom and luggage space.
- **Luggage Forwarding (Takkyubin):** Send large luggage from your Tokyo hotel directly to Kyoto via Yamato Transport (available at hotel front desks). Travel light on the train to avoid stress.

100% GLUTEN-FREE & VEGAN DINING STRATEGY IN JAPAN

Japan traditional cuisine frequently uses soy sauce (containing wheat), dashi (fish stock), and wheat noodles (ramen/udon). However, Japan's GF Vegan movement is thriving in Tokyo and Kyoto with dedicated 100% gluten-free kitchen facilities.

Key GF-Vegan Dining Rules in Japan

- **Tamari vs Standard Soy Sauce:** Standard soy sauce contains 50% wheat. Always request *Tamari* (100% gluten-free soy sauce) or carry your own travel bottle.
- **Cross-Contamination Warning:** Ask if fryers are shared with gluten items. All restaurants recommended below use dedicated 100% GF facilities or safe separation.
- **Essential Apps:** Download *HappyCow* and *Gluten Free Japan Maps* for real-time menu cross-checking.

Top Featured 100% Gluten-Free Vegan Ramen Places

Restaurant	City / District	Specialty	Address
Soranoiro NIPPON	Tokyo Station	100% Vegan GF Brown Rice Noodle Ramen with rich vegetable broth.	Tokyo Ramen Street, B1F Tokyo Station, 1-9-1 Marunouchi, Chiyoda-ku, Tokyo
Vegan Ramen UZU	Kyoto (Nakagyo)	TeamLab immersive digital art dining; 100% GF Vegan Rich Tonkotsu-style broth.	1463 Umezawa-cho, Nakagyo-ku, Kyoto
Gluten Free Ramen Engine	Tokyo (Asakusa)		1-16-11 Asakusa, Taito-ku, Tokyo

Restaurant	City / District	Specialty	Address
		100% Dedicated Gluten-Free kitchen, vegan shoyu and spicy miso ramen.	
Engine Ramen Kyoto	Kyoto (Gion)	Gluten-free & vegan options made with rice noodles & house dashi broth.	584-3 Sanjo-dori, Higashiyama-ku, Kyoto
T's Tantan	Tokyo Station / Ueno	Famous plant-based sesame tantan noodles (Ask for GF glass/rice noodles).	Keiyo Street, JR Tokyo Station (Inside Gates), Chiyoda-ku, Tokyo

14-DAY RELAXED ITINERARY: TOKYO & KYOTO

Week 1: Tokyo — Pop Culture, Shrine Sanctuaries & Gourmet GF

Day 1: Arrival & Seamless Check-in TRANSIT

Arrive at Haneda Airport. Pick up Suica IC Card & Pocket Wi-Fi at airport. Take direct Keikyu Express train to hotel in Shinjuku/Shibuya. Early rest to reset.

Day 2: Akihabara Pop Culture Immersion & GF Ramen POP CULTURE GF DINING

Explore Radio Kaikan, Animate, and Mandarake in Akihabara for anime, gaming, and collectible retro goods. Relaxed stroll without rush.

Dinner: Soranoiro NIPPON — Tokyo Station (Address: B1F Tokyo Station, 1-9-1 Marunouchi, Chiyoda-ku, Tokyo)

Day 3: Meiji Jingu Shrine & Harajuku Culture TEMPLE/SHRINE POP CULTURE

Walk through the serene forest path to **Meiji Jingu Shrine**. Afternoon stroll along Takeshita Street and Cat Street in Harajuku for street fashion and pop accessories.

Location: Meiji Jingu, 1-1 Yoyogikamizoncho, Shibuya-ku, Tokyo

Lunch Spot: Littlebird (100% GF Cafe) — 1-1-20 Yoyogi, Shibuya-ku, Tokyo

Day 4: Ghibli Museum & Kichijoji Park Stroll POP CULTURE

Visit the world-famous **Studio Ghibli Museum** in Mitaka (advance tickets required). Enjoy the tranquil walking trails of Inokashira Park.

Location: Ghibli Museum, 1-1-83 Shimorenjaku, Mitaka-shi, Tokyo

Day 5: Asakusa Senso-ji & Pokemon Center TEMPLE POP CULTURE

Morning visit to Tokyo's oldest temple, **Senso-ji**. Afternoon visit to the Pokemon Center Mega Tokyo and Sunshine City in Ikebukuro.

Location: Senso-ji, 2-3-1 Asakusa, Taito-ku, Tokyo

Dinner: Gluten Free Ramen Engine — 1-16-11 Asakusa, Taito-ku, Tokyo

Day 6: TeamLab Planets & Odaiba Waterfront POP CULTURE

Experience the immersive digital art exhibition **teamLab Planets** in Toyosu. See the giant Life-Sized Unicorn Gundam statue in Odaiba.

Location: teamLab Planets, 6-1-16 Toyosu, Koto-ku, Tokyo

Day 7: Bullet Train to Kyoto (Shinkansen) TRANSIT

Send heavy luggage ahead via Yamato Transport. Board Shinkansen Nozomi (2 hrs 15 mins) to Kyoto. Check into Kyoto hotel and enjoy a tranquil evening in Gion.

Week 2: Kyoto — Ancient Temples, Nintendo Culture & Sacred Groves

Day 8: Fushimi Inari Taisha Shrine SHRINE

Early morning walk through thousands of vermilion Torii gates up Mount Inari. Peaceful, non-crowded morning experience.

Location: 68 Fukakusa Yabunouchicho, Fushimi-ku, Kyoto

Day 9: Arashiyama Bamboo Grove & Tenryu-ji Temple TEMPLE

Explore Tenryu-ji World Heritage Temple and its breathtaking Zen garden, followed by a scenic walk through the Bamboo Grove and Monkey Park Iwatayama.

Location: Tenryu-ji, 68 Susukinobaba-cho, Saga-Tenryuji, Ukyo-ku, Kyoto

Day 10: Kinkaku-ji (Golden Pavilion) & Nintendo Museum TEMPLE POP CULTURE

Visit the iconic shimmering Golden Pavilion (Kinkaku-ji). Afternoon trip to the brand-new **Nintendo Museum in Uji** (Kyoto prefecture).

Location: Kinkaku-ji, 1 Kinkakujicho, Kita-ku, Kyoto

Dinner: Vegan Ramen UZU — 1463 Umezawa-cho, Nakagyo-ku, Kyoto

Day 11: Kiyomizu-dera & Historic Ninenzaka TEMPLE

Marvel at the monumental wooden stage of Kiyomizu-dera Temple. Wander historic stone-paved streets of Ninenzaka & Sannenzaka for tea houses and traditional crafts.

Location: Kiyomizu-dera, 1-294 Kiyomizu, Higashiyama-ku, Kyoto

Day 12: Day Trip to Nara (Deer Park & Todai-ji Temple) TEMPLE

Short 45-minute train trip to Nara. Visit Todai-ji Temple housing the Great Buddha (Daibutsu) and bow with friendly free-roaming Nara deer.

Location: Todai-ji, 406-1 Zoshicho, Nara-shi, Nara

Day 13: Kyoto Manga Museum & Gion Corner Evening POP CULTURE

Browse thousands of translated manga at Kyoto International Manga Museum. Evening walk through historic Gion preserved geisha district.

Location: Kyoto Manga Museum, Karasuma-Oike, Nakagyo-ku, Kyoto

Day 14: Return to Tokyo & Departure TRANSIT

Take direct Shinkansen back to Tokyo Haneda / Narita Airport for evening flight home. Relaxed departure with zero stress.

ESSENTIAL JAPANESE PHRASES FOR DIETARY REQUIREMENTS & TRAVEL

Show these phrases to restaurant staff to ensure 100% gluten-free and vegan preparation.

English Translation	Japanese (Kanji / Kana)	Pronunciation (Romaji)
I have a severe wheat / gluten allergy.	小麦アレルギーがあります。	Komugi arerugi- ga arimasu.
Is this gluten-free?	これはグルテンフリーですか？	Kore wa guruten furi- desu ka?
Does this contain soy sauce or dashi?	醤油や出汁は入っていますか？	Shoyu ya dashi wa itte imasu ka?
I am vegan. I don't eat meat, fish, or eggs.	ヴィーガンです。肉、魚、卵は食べません。	Vi-gan desu. Niku, sakana, tamago wa tabemasen.
Do you have gluten-free ramen?	グルテンフリーのラーメンはありますか？	Guruten furi- no raamen wa arimasu ka?
Thank you very much!	ありがとうございます！	Arigatou gozaimasu!
Where is the temple / shrine?	お寺 / 神社はどこですか？	Otera / Jinja wa doko desu ka?

BONUS CONCEPT: "ZENGF TRAVEL APP" FEATURES

Architectural concept for a specialized travel app tailored to sensitive dietary relaxed travelers:

- **Dietary Scanner:** Real-time OCR camera tool that scans Japanese food labels for wheat (小麦), soy sauce (醤油), and animal dashi.
- **Verified Safe Map:** Filtered GPS map showing only 100% GF and Vegan certified restaurants across Japan.
- **Delay Guardian:** Live flight & Shinkansen tracker with automatic re-booking suggestions in case of transport delays.
- **Chef Communication Cards:** Full-screen bilingual dietary request cards to present directly to kitchen staff.